

FROM THE CHILDREN AND FAMILY MINISTRY

Overbrook Presbyterian Church

Thursday in the XVI Week of the Season after Pentecost A 2023
September 21, 2023

Greetings, Overbrook,

As we journey together in this transformative season, active work on the Children's and Families' Prayerground continues. This endeavor is a testament to our community's shared vision of increasing accessibility for all who worship at The OPC Crossroads. Since our proposal was approved earlier this Spring, the CFM has been humbled by members' expressions of excitement, love, and grace. Now in the final stages of implementation, we wish to provide the congregation with a comprehensive update on our ministry team's progress on the Prayerground to date:

On the 7th of September, the Session's Pew Removal Task Force took the essential step of safely storing recently retired pews in the church's crypt – a space Leonard and Lisa diligently oversee. The work of rehoming these artifacts was done with the utmost care and deepest respect for the history and legacy of this church.

Days earlier, a talkback session between the CFM and congregation members was held in the chapel after worship. This was a helpful and heartening experience. Members of the CFM Committee were grateful for the engagement at the talkback, including numerous thoughtful queries raised concerning the liturgical and participatory needs of children and caregivers. We welcome anyone curious about the spiritual, theological, liturgical, pedagogical, and practical matters surrounding the Prayerground to submit questions, or attend additional talkbacks later this Fall.

Now in the middle of September, the CFM has moved much closer to the finish line. We are currently in the “design and sourcing phase” of the project, although this is not yet apparent when one enters our Sanctuary. With the invisible work of the Prayerground chugging along at an exciting pace, the CFM has three pieces of good to share:

Nº1 Two well-credentialled designers – parents of our congregation – and our Director of CFM, have finalized important design decisions, such as the Prayerground's layout, textiles, and furnishings. Design decisions are firmly rooted in the interest of aligning with Overbrook's aesthetic character, its core value of welcome, ecological sustainability, and its persistent push for accessibility throughout its buildings and grounds.

Nº2 Judy Williamson, an ardent supporter of the Prayerground since its inception, is working to grow a team of Prayerground Stewards who will serve as trained facilitators on Sunday mornings. If you are interested in pioneering new ministry with Judy, and being part of her engaging ministry team, please reach out to her.

Nº3 CFM's community partners and donors are partnering with the ministry through generous acts of design, sustainable sourcing, and restoration. First, our heartfelt thanks go to Anne Foote for her donation of wooden Montessori-style children's furniture. Anne's gift, an elegant table and chair set, and two other chairs, have enabled the ministry to keep project costs low while utilizing only quality materials we can all feel proud of. Most especially, we are grateful for receiving furnishings that keep our kids safe, engaged, and comfortable. Thank you for your care, Anne. Additionally, we extend gratitude to our partners in restoration at Chairloom in Narberth, who have provided pro bono design consulting and generous donations of velvet fabric to upholster furnishings of the Prayerground space. Our friends at Chairloom have also introduced us to local furniture builder and craftsman Breck Brunson (@Breckbuilt). In his Northern Liberties studio, Breck is currently overseeing the transformation of an old pew sidelined decades ago due to wear, into a custom bookshelf / spatial boundary for the Prayerground. Many thanks to this new friend and talented artisan.

So, where are we now? Currently, leaders in the CFM are finalizing a bespoke carpeting solution which is tailored to meet a variety of needs including aesthetic, traffic, maintenance, and health + safety considerations. A small team is being recruited to help install and cut the carpet, as well as assemble other aspects of the Prayerground. If you are interested in spending some time working in the Sanctuary, please reach out to Molly Burke.

While the CFM anticipates opening the Prayerground by the end of October, sustainable sourcing methods and local artisans simply cannot be rushed. A lead time of 4-6 weeks is to be expected, but we are so blessed to be working with contractors who deliver on their deadlines with remarkable results. Please continue praying for all the hands and hearts diligently at work during this integral stage of this project. Your kind patience and deep faith fuels our energy and imagination. We encourage your continued questions and welcome your curiosity *at any time*.

Gratefully yours, in Christ,

Anthony M. Carrella, Director of Children and Family Ministry

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Molly Andrews Burke, Chair of Children and Family Ministry Committee '23-25

Judy Williamson, Member of the Children and Family Ministry Committee & Prayerground Ministry Coordinator